

English idioms and phrasal verbs

The story behind this collection

My name is Vladislav. I'm not a native English speaker, but for the last three years, I've been studying the language — both for work and for fun.

This project began when I first watched "**Desperate Housewives**", the wonderful series by Marc Cherry. Every episode was packed with idioms and natural expressions that I never encountered in textbooks. I started writing them down, first for myself, then realizing they could help other learners like me — people who want to master **real, living English**, not just the grammar from school or university materials.

This collection is the result. It's a growing phrasebook built from the shows we watch, the games we play, and the conversations we hear.

Want to contribute?

Use the link below to visit the GitHub repository, where you can suggest new idioms, phrasal verbs, or examples.

<https://github.com/Vlad-Vasinev/real-english-idioms>

Let's find and preserve as many authentic phrases as we can together!

Best wishes,
Vladislav

A

Phrase	Meaning
“Akin to (something)”	similar <i>“They speak a language akin to French.”</i>
“About time”	it should happen or done now <i>“It is about time you got here.”</i>
“A glutton for punishment”	a person who is always eager to take hard or unpleasant tasks <i>“He is a real glutton for punishment, taking on all that extra work in the office.”</i>
“All-time big”	smth is the biggest, best or most extreme in history up to the present moment <i>“That player is an all-time great in football.”</i>
“Along the way”	during a journey, process, or series of events <i>“We stopped for coffee along the way to the mountains.”</i>
“A pat on the back”	an expression of approval or congratulation <i>“They deserved a pat on the back for a job well done.”</i>
“Alive and kicking”	to continue to live and exist <i>“Jeck’ll be there in time, if he is still alive and kicking.”</i>
“Air grievances”	to express complaints, publicly or formally <i>“I am going to air my grievances online by giving them a bad review.”</i>
“Are we clear?”	check for mutual understanding <i>“Just to be clear, I am not responsible for that.”</i>

[illegible]

B

Phrase	Meaning
“Bottom line”	the fundamental and most important factor <i>“The bottom line is that they lost the game.”</i>
“Break the ice”	to do or say smth to relieve tension or get conversation going(in a strained situation) <i>“He suggested that we play a game to break the ice.”</i>
“Break it down”	to simplify a complex topic by explaining it in smaller steps <i>“Let me break it down for you.”</i>
“Blend in”	to look, act, or be similar to your surroundings <i>“We tried to blend into the crowd.”</i>
“Baptism of fire”	a difficult introduction to a new job or activity <i>“When I started my own small business, I went through a baptism of fire.”</i>
“Better be safe than sorry”	said when you think it is better to not take the risk <i>“Make sure you take an umbrella, It’s sunny now, but better be safe than sorry.”</i>
“Be hyped”	very enthusiastic(about smth) <i>“I’m so hyped for the movie premiere!”</i>
“Bolt out the door”	to leave a place suddenly <i>“The cat bolted out the door when the dog appeared.”</i>
“Bad-mouthing”	criticise someone behind their back <i>“No one wants to hire him, he bad-mouths a prior employee.”</i>

B

Phrase	Meaning
“By the skin of your teeth”	just barely, very narrowly <i>“He passed the final exam by the skin of his teeth.”</i>
“Be at the top of your game”	to perform extremely well in a sport, job, etc <i>“Even at 40, that tennis player is still top of her game.”</i>
“Beck and call”	always having to be ready or obey <i>“She was confined to a wheelchair but had a private nurse at her beck and call.”</i>
“Be grounded”	punishment: not leaving the house except to go to school <i>“She was grounded for a month because of her bad grades at school.”</i>
“Be on your guard”	to be careful to avoid being tricked or getting into a dangerous situation <i>“You always have to be on your guard against pickpockets.”</i>
“Be up to smth”	person is doing or planning smth and keeping it in secret <i>“She didn’t show at our meeting and her phone went silent, she is definitely up to something.”</i>
“Brace yourself”	to prepare for smth difficult, unpleasant <i>“This final test has to be hard, brace yourself.”</i>
“Bring the rain”	military: to call a massive artillery <i>“We are in position and ready, bring the rain!”</i>
“By the book”	strictly according to the rules <i>“A cop who doesn’t exactly play it by the book.”</i>
“Broad question”	doesn’t have one correct answer <i>“Tell me about the Civil War.”</i> <i>“What exactly? That is a broad question.”</i>

[illegible]



Phrase	Meaning
“Cry me a river”	an idiom used to dismiss someone’s complaints or self-pity as exaggerated and undeserving of sympathy <i>“You can cry me a river, but it won’t change my decision.”</i>
“Carry on”	continue an activity or task <i>“She carried on watching the TV.”</i>
“Crybaby”	someone who tries very easily and complains a lot <i>“Don’t be such a crybaby, it’s only a scratch.”</i>
“Catch up”	succeed in reaching a person who is ahead of one <i>“He stopped and waited for Lily to catch up.”</i>
“Crack on”	proceed or progress quickly <i>“We’ll crack on with the rest of the job this month.”</i>
“Chock-full (of them)”	something is completely full, packed to the limit <i>“The stadium was chock-full of fans.”</i>
“Close to the edge”	being in a risky situation <i>“The company is close to the edge of bankruptcy.”</i>
“Come to one’s senses”	start to think and behave reasonably after a period of foolishness <i>“Phil finally came to his senses and admitted he needed help with his drinking problems.”</i>
“Call the shots”	take the initiative <i>“You are the boss here - you get to call the shots.”</i>

D

Phrase	Meaning
<i>“Double down on something”</i>	to continue to do smth in an even more determined way than before <i>“A company might double down on marketing efforts for a struggling product.”</i>
<i>“Drop the ball”</i>	to make a mistake, fail to do smth important, or miss an opportunity <i>“He wants to see me fail, I am not afraid, I won’t drop the ball.”</i>
<i>“Don’t play coy (with me)”</i>	stop pretending to be shy, innocent or uncertain <i>“You have strong ideas about this project, so, don’t play coy, tell us what you really think.”</i>
<i>“Dilly-Dally”</i>	waste time through aimless wandering or indecision <i>“Don’t dilly-dally for too long.”</i>
<i>“Deal in absolutes”</i>	to view the world in black-d-white, using rigid, unchanging principles, without considering nuance, context, or grey areas <i>“You are either with us, or you are with the terrorists.”</i>
<i>“Don’t give a damn(shit/crap)”</i>	not care at all <i>“They don’t give damn about the environment.”</i>
<i>“Doted on”</i>	to love someone completely and believe they are perfect <i>“He dotes on the new baby.”</i>
<i>“Due to”</i>	because of smth <i>“Due to the complaints of parents he lost his job.”</i>

[illegible]

E

Phrase	Meaning
<i>“End is in sight”</i>	you are close to finishing smth difficult <i>“After working all night, the end is finally in sight for this report.”</i>
<i>“Everything comes with a price”</i>	every decision involves giving smth up for smth else <i>“Fame comes at a price, as she lost all her privacy.”</i>
<i>“Embark on”</i>	to start a new journey, project or significant undertaking(challenging and important) <i>“They embarked on their trip to America.”</i>

[illegible]

G

Phrase	Meaning
“Get (it) over with”	complete an unpleasant or tedious but necessary task promptly <i>“I’ll be glad to get these exams over with.”</i>
“Get together”	assemble socially or cooperate <i>“We must get together for a drink sometime.”</i>
“Get to second base”	dating: to move beyond kissing (first base) to more involved touching, fondling above the breasts <i>“They kissed on their first date, but managed to get to second base by the end of their third night out.”</i>
“Get off on (something)”	to find smth exciting, especially in a sexual way <i>“Dave likes power, he gets off on it.”</i>
“Go viral”	when content spreads quickly and widely <i>“The cat video went viral.”</i>
“Get down to”	to begin to do smth, to give serious attention to smth <i>“I must get down to booking the hotels.”</i>
“Get your knickers in a twist”	become upset or angry <i>“Don’t get your knickers in a twist. I’ll be ready in a minute.”</i>
“Get it over with”	to finish or reach the end of some unpleasant work <i>“I’ll be glad to get these exams over with.”</i>
“Given the lack”	because there is not enough or any of smth <i>“Given the lack of evidence, the case was dismissed.”</i>



Phrase	Meaning
“Hold your horses”	wait for a moment <i>“Just hold your horses, let’s think about it for a moment.”</i>
“High five”	greet somebody by slapping the palms <i>“The two officers high-five each other.”</i>
“Here is the rub on this”	here is the difficult part, problem or obstacle (originally from Shakespeare’s Hamlet) <i>“We can buy the house, but there’s a rub: we can’t afford mortgage.”</i>
“Have a blast”	to have a really fun, exciting time <i>“Hope you have a blast on vacation.”</i>
“Hang back”	remain behind <i>“They were hanging back, each unwilling to speak first.”</i>
“Have a look”	briefly examine smth <i>“Can you have a look at this photo?”</i>
“Hold your peace”	remain silent about smth <i>“You must hold your peace and accept changes.”</i>
“Have a way with”	have a particular talent for dealing with or ability in <i>“She has got a way with animals.”</i>

Phrase	Meaning
<i>“In an effort to”</i>	with the aim of, trying to, or in an attempt to achieve a specific goal or outcome <i>“The company launched a campaign in an effort to increase sales.”</i>
<i>“It clouds your thinking”</i> same as “short-sighted thinking”	not thinking enough about how an action’ll affect the future <i>“Don’t let your anger cloud your thinking.”</i>
<i>“It would stand to reason”</i>	it is obvious or logical <i>“It stands to reason that if you are friendly to people you’ll get more back.”</i>
<i>“I can relate”</i>	you understand and share somebody’s feelings or experiences <i>“Person A: I’m so stressed about this deadline.”</i> <i>“Person B: I can relate.”</i>
<i>“I’m gonna level with you”</i>	i am gonna be honest with you <i>“He never leveled with his parents about the accident.”</i>
<i>“I have a visual”</i>	clearly see smth, spot a target... <i>“Person A: Can you see the house?”</i> <i>“Person B: Yes, I have a visual.”</i>
<i>“It could take a while”</i>	a task or process will require significant, but unspecified, amount of time <i>“I’m working on the report, but it could take a while”</i>
<i>“In all likelihood”</i>	high probability <i>“In all likelihood, the flight will be delayed due to the storm.”</i>



English phrases(B1, B2, C1, C2)

[illegible]



Phrase	Meaning
“Lock in”	to focus intensely on smth <i>“I have a big test tomorrow, I need to lock in tonight.”</i>
“Like a frog in a pond”	feeling insignificant or out of place in a large, overwhelming environment where other seem more skilled or important <i>“Someone new to a huge corporation might feel like a little frog in a big pond.”</i>
“Letdown”	disappointment <i>“The election was a bit of let-down.”</i>
“Leg up”	gain some advantage <i>“This technology will give it a leg up on the competition.”</i>
“Likewise”	in the same way / similar / also <i>“Person A: Pleased to meet you.”</i> <i>“Person B: Likewise.”</i>
“Limbo”	an uncertain situation that you can’t control <i>“We felt that we were left in limbo wondering what was happening.”</i>
“Lying around”	to spend time being idle or relaxing <i>“We spend the weekend just lying around.”</i>
“Loose cannon”	an unpredictable or uncontrolled person who is liable to cause unintentional damage <i>“I don’t think we can take a risk on a loose cannon like him running our country.”</i>
“Let me get this straight”	let me make sure that I have a clear understanding of topic or situation <i>“You need to get your facts straight.”</i>



Phrase	Meaning
“Like it matters”	to express that smth is unimportant insignificant, or doesn't make any difference <i><u>“Why would I care what your name is, like it matters.”</u></i>
“Lift a finger”	make a slightest effort to do smth, especially to help someone <i><u>“He never lifted a finger to help Jimmy released from prison.”</u></i>
“Laying waste”	to completely destroy, ruin smth <i><u>“The hurricane laid waste to the coastal towns.”</u></i>



Phrase	Meaning
“Make up for it”	to compensate for a mistake, loss, or shortcoming by doing smth positive to balance it(correcting a mistake) <u>“He bought me dinner to make up for being so late the day before.”</u>
“Mark my words”	pay close attention to what I’m saying, because it’s important and will definitely happen <u>“He’ll cause trouble - you mark my words!.”</u>
“Make (something) up”	device or create a story or plan <u>“She enjoyed making up tall tales.”</u>
“Make it clear”	to explain smth so there is no confusion <u>“We need to make things clear before we sign a contract.”</u>
“Make up a story on the fly”	invent smth, sometimes in order to deceive people <u>“The new rule seems to have been created on the fly.”</u>
“Make exit”	to leave a place or situation <u>“She made a hasty exit after the argument.”</u>
“Make it count”	get the best possible result from a situation <u>“You only have one shot at this interview, so make it count.”</u>
“Make up for lost time”	to enjoy an experience as much as possible because you did not have the opportunity to do it earlier in life <u>“I didn’t travel much in my twenties but I’m certainly making up for lost time now.”</u>

[illegible]

[illegible]

[illegible]

P

Phrase	Meaning
<i>“Partners don’t ditch partners”</i>	true partners support each other, remain loyal and don’t abandon each other when things get tough <i>“Partners don’t ditch partners. I didn’t leave you there, I’ll be here with you as well.”</i>
<i>“Platonic relationship”</i>	a deep, intimate friendship with strong emotional connection, trust, and support, but without any romantic or sexual attraction <i>“Best friends who share everything.”</i>
<i>“Put up with”</i>	tolerate or endure smth <i>“I’m too tired to put up with any nonsense.”</i>
<i>“Pedal to the metal”</i>	at full speed <i>“She loved carrying down the highway with the pedal to the metal.”</i>
<i>“Present and accounted for”</i>	from military: used to say that all people that re supposed to be at a place or event are there <i>“After a fire drill, a teacher confirms: All students are present and accounted for.”</i>
<i>“Patch up”</i>	to temporarily mend smth broken, give quick first aid <i>“She managed to patch up the old fence before winter.”</i>
<i>“Pay back”</i>	take revenge on someone <i>“When someone does you wrong, the first instinct is to pay them back for hurting you.”</i>
<i>“Pay the price”</i>	to suffer negative consequences or unpleasant results of your own actions <i>“If you don’t study, you’ll pay the price on the exam.”</i>

[illegible]

R

Phrase	Meaning
“Ring the bell”	sound vaguely familiar <i>“The name rings a bell.”</i>
“Rule of thumb”	a broadly accurate guide or principle based on practise rather than theory <i>“A good rule of thumb is that a portion of rice is two handfuls.”</i>
“Root for”	to hope for success of someone / smth <i>“The vast majority of the fans rooting for Mexico.”</i>
“Real deal”	a person or thing that is a good example of their kind <i>“His performance proved he is a real deal.”</i>
“Running low”	you have a small supply of something <i>“We are running low on cash.”</i>
“Remain to be seen”	it is not yet certain <i>“She has broken her leg. But it remains to be seen how badly.”</i>

S

Phrase	Meaning
“Second to none”	better than all others <i>“His cakes are second to none.”</i>
“Suck up”	behave obsequiously, especially for one’s own advantage <i>“She’s always sucking up to the boss.”</i>
“Shut down”	to reject somebody <i>“He asked her out, but she shut him down immediately.”</i>
“Stay tuned”	to keep watching or listening a broadcast <i>“Stay tuned for our breaking news report.”</i>
“Step in”	become involve in a difficult situation <i>“Palace officials asked the government to step in.”</i>
“Scale down”	reduce in size <i>“Manufacturing capacity has been scaled down.”</i>
“Stick around”	remain in or near a place <i>“I would like to stick around and watch the game.”</i>
“Simply put”	to explain smth in a clear, basic way <i>“Simply put, the economy is in trouble.”</i>
“Short time ago”	smth happened recently <i>“I saw her a short time ago.”</i>
“Stand for (smth)”	to support or represent a particular idea or set of ideas <i>“This party stands for lower taxes and individual freedom.”</i>
“Settle old scores”	take a revenge on someone <i>“The president used his speech to settle some old scores.”</i>

[illegible]



Phrase	Meaning
<i>“Time is of the essence”</i>	promptness is crucial <i>“The patient condition is critical, so time is of the essence for the surgery.”</i>
<i>“To be in a sync”</i>	working together harmoniously <i>“We have been feeling a little out of sync with each other lately.”</i>
<i>“This is a make it or break it”</i>	be the factor which decides whether (smth) will succeed or fail <i>“The soundtrack can make or break a production.”</i>
<i>“Train wreck”</i>	smth that fails completely <i>“The movie was a train wreck.”</i>
<i>“To be taken aback”</i>	be surprised or shocked <i>“He was taken aback by her directness.”</i>
<i>“Take a toll”</i>	have an adverse effect <i>“Years of working hard have taken their toll on his body.”</i>
<i>“To be neck-deep(involved)”</i>	to be very deeply involved in something <i>“The team was neck-deep in project.”</i>
<i>“To be punched”</i>	you have been tricked, fooled or made fun of <i>“I totally got punched.”</i>
<i>“That would be a game”</i>	fun challenge, clever strategy or that is a smart move <i>“Person A: Let’s go hiking!”</i> <i>“Person B: Sure, that would be a game for me!”</i>
<i>“Take over”</i>	to get control of smth <i>“In 1938 the Nazis took over.”</i>



Phrase	Meaning
“Talk a good game”	to speak very convincingly about one’s plans abilities or intensions or that they can do smth even though it is not true <i>“Politicians talk a good game but don’t act.”</i>
“Take smth for granted”	if you take situation or people for granted, you do not realize or show that you are grateful for how much you get from them <i>“You just take it for granted that people over a certain age can drive.”</i>
“Toady”	full of praise or artificially pleasant to someone in authority <i>“He offered a toadying tribute to his leader.”</i>
“Think over”	consider smth carefully <i>“He told the player to go home and think over his offer.”</i>
“The fruits of someone’s labor”	rewards, benefits come from hard work and effort <i>“After years of saving, she could finally enjoy the fruits of her labor as she bought her dream house.”</i>
“Take five”	have a short break <i>“Our crew took five at a little cafe nearby.”</i>
“To brief (you) in person”	give some details, instructions directly (personally) <i>“I need to brief you in person on the new client.”</i>
“Tight leash”	to get control of smth <i>“Parents often keep teenagers on a tight leash for their safety.”</i>

[illegible]



Phrase	Meaning
<i>“We got you covered”</i>	“don’t worry, we’ll handle it” (take care of a task) <i>“Forgot your notes? No worries, I’ve got you covered.”</i>
<i>“Watch out!”</i>	used for warning someone of danger <i>“Watch out! There is a car coming!”</i>
<i>“Way too”</i>	much too <i>“The soup is way too hot.”</i>
<i>“When push comes to show”</i>	if absolutely necessary <i>“When push came to show, I always stood up for him.”</i>
<i>“When it comes to”</i>	when the specified matter is under consideration <i>“It pays to be proactive when it comes to your health.”</i>
<i>“What do you make of it?”</i>	a request for someone’s interpretation, asking for general view <i>“What do you make of these test results?”</i>
<i>“Waking nightmare”</i>	as a metaphor(distressing life situation) <i>“Her first meeting with the boss was such a waking nightmare.”</i>
<i>“When plans come together”</i>	different elements successfully combine, making a complex idea(project or plan) work effectively, usually after a period of preparation <i>“At last, his plan was coming together.”</i>
<i>“What in blazes”</i>	used as an intensifier after a question <i>“What in blazes is going on here?”</i>

[illegible]



Phrase	Meaning
<i>“You’re kidding me”</i>	used to express shock, disbelief of surprise <i>“You won the lottery? Are you kidding me?!”</i>
<i>“You can’t put a price on it”</i>	smth is extremely valuable, precious (beyond monetary) <i>“You can’t put a price on child’s laughter.”</i>
<i>“You scratch my back and I’ll scratch yours”</i>	if you do me a favour, I’ll return it(the origin goes back to 17th century - English navy) <i>“I’ll cook dinner tonight if you take out the trash tomorrow. You scratch my back, I’ll scratch yours”</i>
<i>“Yielded results”</i>	get the outcome you were looking for <i>“The search yielded several potential matches.”</i>
<i>“You lost me”</i>	i don’t understand what you are saying <i>“Wait, you lost me. Can you start over from the beginning?”</i>

License

This phrase collection is an open educational resource.

© 2024 Vladislav (and contributors)

It is licensed under the Creative Commons Attribution-ShareAlike 4.0 International License (CC BY-SA 4.0).

This means you are free to:

Share — copy and redistribute the material in any medium or format.

Adapt — remix, transform, and build upon the material for any purpose, even commercially.

Under the following terms:

Attribution — You must give appropriate credit, provide a link to the license, and indicate if changes were made.

ShareAlike — If you remix, transform, or build upon the material, you must distribute your contributions under the same license as the original.

For more details, visit: <https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-sa/4.0/>